these offenders has been required to pay for their statements by relinquishing their seats on Prime Minister Modi's Council of Ministers.

There was the Shiv Sena MP, a member of the ruling coalition, shoving food down the throat of a fasting Muslim during Ramzan, and getting away without the slightest censure from the ruling party.[17] There have been numerous incidents of communal violence, instigated for political purposes no doubt, but instilling fear in the targeted minorities. And there was the faintly ridiculous episode of the mass conversion of fifty-seven bewildered Bengali Muslims in Agra, through a mix of intimidation and inducement, under the Sangh Parivar's long-dormant '*ghar wapsi'* scheme.[18] (Many of them, it seems, were illegal immigrants from Bangladesh, who thought that signing up would be an excellent dodge to regularise their status in India.)

The resultant uproar put '*ghar wapsi*' on the back burner, but the 'reconversion' to the parent faith of those Indians who are not Hindu remains a cherished Hindutva project. As Manmohan Vaidya of the RSS has explained: 'Ghar wapsi is a natural urge to connect to our roots.'

So Smt. Swaraj's declaration joins a long list of statements and actions by our Hindutva-inspired rulers that cumulatively have stirred disquiet across the country.

Is this wise? It is ironic that Prime Minister Modi keeps on emphasising the message of development and economic transformation, while his aides persist in raising bogeys that their leader has been attempting to lay to rest. There is little doubt that after the BJP rode to power on a mantra of inclusive development 'sab ka saath, sab ka vikas' its Hindutva core has begun to take advantage of its proximity to government to assertively push a sectarian agenda. As has been noted, Hindutva acolytes are being appointed to research professorships and vice-chancellorships; the Indian Council of Historical Research was headed for three years by a true believer whose Hindutva credentials reportedly outshine his historical ones, textbooks in BJP-ruled states like Maharashtra and Rajasthan are being rewritten to privilege ancient Hindu glories, and Sanskrit is being promoted. Some of this, one might argue, is inevitable in any democracy after a transfer of power from one ruling dispensation to another. But some, at least, distracts from the